CSCI 4511W Writing Assignment 1

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1 Do you agree with the paper on the importance of ethics in AI? Why?

Kuiper's main argument is that ethics should encourage positive-sum and discourage negative-sum interactions. For ethics in AI then, I agree we should create AI that also maximizes positive-sum interactions. However, positive-sum is not always a two-party calculation, and this is where I think it gets complicated. The positive-sum beyond you and another person could include your community, the environment, the future, resources, and perhaps infinitely many more. Because even humans are blinded to the externalities of our own decisions it will be very hard to create an AI that does consider all externalities. However, until we can create an AI that does this, the positive-sum game will always be flawed; although the AI will make the best decision for all parties involved, it may be irreversibly damaging to the environment.

This also comes in with the idea of ethical governance. Kuiper gives the example of governing lethal robots; we could equip them with an "ethical governor" based on the Laws of War and Rules of Engagement. Without human emotion, robots might actually be more ethical and they could be programmed to maximize societal utility. However, a future with only hard rules is very bleak. I think that human rules and human nature complement each other and one without the other would create a world that spirals away from our desired outcome. Kuiper hints at this when he talks about human sub-optimal decisions being better for cooperation; the rational solution for many games results in poor outcomes, while human decisions tend to create even better outcomes. This is because humans give social cues to cooperate through unoptimal social cues.

Kuiper claims that we want to maximize positive-sum interactions over negative-sum interactions; cooperation produces more value. I agree that this is very important especially as robots begin to take on the same standing as people in terms of societal positions. It will be increasingly important that robots prioritize cooperation with humans. Overall, I agree that we should try to maximize the positive-sum interactions. I want to add on some thoughts about the results of unethical behavior in AI. If robots are to join our society and follow

our ethical rules, then they are also subject to other human things. Since humans have consequences when they commit crimes against social norms, robots should as well. But does this make sense? Society and nations are held together by the idea of a central governing body having the right to punish. Does it make sense to punish something that only made the decisions it was designed to make?

2 In the example you have chosen, do you agree with the Social Norm presented in the paper? Why or why not? Would you add any?

In Sharing the Wealth, Kuiper presents the social norm "Those who contribute to the success of a collective effort, will share in the benefits." Kuiper then talks about how this social norm has been completely violated by our business principles of benefiting the shareholders first. While overall wealth has risen, the workers and customers are among the groups that have barely reaped any of that wealth. While I agree with the principles of this social norm, much like the social norms for individual user models, almost none of it has every been kept. This begs the question, is it really a social norm if it has never been the norm? Or even, can social norms become outdated if it is no longer the norm? For sharing the wealth, I would add the social norm that "Those who did not sow should not reap." So that anyone not directly involved in the efforts of aggrandizement should not benefit.